



Career Research and Decision Making

OPTIMA ACADEMY ONLINE · FAMILY COURSE OVERVIEW · GRADES 9–12 · ONE SEMESTER

~4¼ hrs per week · 50 min/day, M–F

About this overview. This document is an example of how the course might be taught. Scholars may see some variation in activities and projects from course to course, and between the live school and On-Demand. Each teacher also leans into their own strengths and passions; the structure, expectations, and time commitment below are representative of the course as designed.

Career Research and Decision Making invites scholars to think seriously about their vocations. Scholars examine their own strengths and interests in dialogue with real possibilities — trade school, apprenticeships, microcredentials, military service, work, gap years, and two- and four-year college — and learn current best practices for finding and applying for jobs. By semester's end each scholar carries away a Canvas ePortfolio with professional drafts of a resume, a cover letter, and a practice interview. The course assumes that meaningful work is part of a meaningful life.

THE YEAR AT A GLANCE

1 Introduction: Taking Personal Stock (Weeks 1–2)

Post-high-school education and career paths, and an honest self-assessment of strengths and interests.

3 Your Future, Your Plan (Weeks 5–9)

The full menu of paths: trade school, apprenticeships, microcredentials (scholars earn a first one), military service, skilled work, gap years, and two- and four-year college research.

5 Landing a Job (Weeks 14–17)

Searching, applying, interview preparation and execution, follow-up, and succeeding from the first day on the job.

2 Essential Skills (Weeks 3–4)

Time management and goal setting; active reading, memory, and note-taking; critical thinking, research, and presentation; collaboration, stress management, and test preparation.

4 Soft Skills and Your Personal Brand (Weeks 10–13)

Communication that works, adapting to changed plans, writing a real resume, networking as a growth strategy, and smart social media presence.

A TYPICAL WEEK

- One to two lessons per week across the seventeen-week semester.
- Practical artifacts accumulate in a Canvas ePortfolio: self-assessments, research, a resume, a cover letter, and a practice interview.
- Assignments open at the start of each quarter, with due dates that pace the work.
- Required office-hours check-ins connect each scholar with the facilitator.

TIME COMMITMENT

250 minutes / week

≈ 50 minutes a day, Monday–Friday, for one semester

- Lessons and ePortfolio work fill most of the scheduled time.
- Project weeks — resume, cover letter, interview — may run longer.

WHAT SCHOLARS NEED

- A computer with reliable internet and access to Canvas.
- A notebook for self-assessment and research notes.
- The Canvas ePortfolio, built up across the semester.

Grading at a glance: Asynchronous homework 60% · Projects 30% · Synchronous activities 10%

On-Demand (asynchronous). Scholars move through the course at their own pace, with due dates to keep the year on track. An Optima teacher is available throughout for support, feedback, and grading.

Live school. Live-school scholars take this same course on Optima's VR campus with a teacher and classmates, when offered live; for 2026–27 it is listed as an On-Demand course.